

SECTION FIVE

GOVERNMENT, POWER & LAW

Who holds power? How did they get it? What laws govern your world? These questions matter because political structures create the obstacles, stakes, and pressures that shape your characters' choices.

The Iron Cage Principle

The political system in your world should function as an iron cage around your romance. Not a backdrop. Not a setting. A cage.

An iron cage means your characters can see right through the bars and reach right through the bars to touch or even hold onto one another. But they can't get out without breaking something, and when something breaks, there will be repercussions that extend far beyond the two of them. The cage is the law that forbids their union. The war that puts them on opposite sides. The court that watches their every move. The prophecy that demands they sacrifice each other for the realm.

What separates an iron cage from simply a barrier is that the cage doesn't care about the feelings of your characters. A personal obstacle, like a fear of vulnerability, can be worked through with patience and emotional growth. An iron cage can't be talked away. The law doesn't soften because they're in love. The political marriage doesn't dissolve because they've had a meaningful conversation. The court's surveillance doesn't pause because they need a private moment.

The greatest romantasy stories use the cage to accomplish two things simultaneously. It creates the external pressure that makes the romance dangerous, and it creates the forced proximity that makes the romance inevitable. Your couple is stuck in the same cage together – that's why they fall in love, and that's why falling in love is the riskiest action they could take.

Every decision in this section should serve the cage. When you choose a government type, you're choosing what the bars are made of. When you define your laws, you're deciding how strong those bars are. When you build your court, you're designing the space inside the cage where your characters must find each other while the world watches.

What is the iron cage around your romance?

The cage is the structural force that keeps your characters apart — not a personal flaw or misunderstanding, but a system, law, or political reality that doesn't care about their feelings. Name it specifically.

YOUR ANSWER

Why can't your characters simply walk away from the cage?

An iron cage only works if leaving it would break something bigger than the relationship. What's at stake beyond the two of them?

YOUR ANSWER

Politics in Romantasy

Politics in romantasy functions as external pressure, forces beyond your characters' control that forbid, compel, or complicate their relationship. Unlike internal obstacles (fear, trust issues, personal history), political obstacles exist whether your characters want them to or not.

Political pressure works on romance in three ways:

Politics as Prohibition

Laws and political structures that forbid the relationship:

- Marriage laws that make their union illegal
- Class systems that make their relationship scandalous
- Species laws that criminalise their love
- Political enemies who can't be seen to fraternise

Politics as Compulsion

Political forces that push characters together against their will:

- Arranged marriages for alliance or peace
- Political necessity requiring cooperation
- Shared enemies creating forced alliance
- Diplomatic situations demanding proximity

Politics as Stakes

What characters risk by pursuing the relationship:

- Execution, imprisonment, exile for illegal unions
- Loss of title, inheritance, political position
- War, broken treaties, political chaos
- Harm to family, faction, or nation

The most compelling political obstacles are ones characters can't simply ignore or talk their way out of. The law doesn't care that they're in love. The war doesn't pause for their feelings. The political marriage is happening whether they want it or not.

From Political Pressure to Romantic Tension

The trick to making politics serve your romance is understanding that every big political event needs a personal emotional consequence for your characters. A war isn't just a war. It's the reason he can't

sleep beside her without flinching. A trade embargo isn't just economics. It's the reason she has to choose between feeding her people and protecting the man who controls the supply lines.

MACRO POLITICAL STAKE	MICRO ROMANTIC OBSTACLE
Global war or conflict	Vulnerability feels like political treason. Letting your guard down could get your people killed.
Theocratic law or doctrine	The act of intimacy is criminalised by the state. Desire itself becomes a sin.
Class or caste divide	The couple must sacrifice their status or safety to be together. One world must be abandoned.
Fragile court alliances	The relationship is under constant public scrutiny. Every glance is analysed for political meaning.
Resource scarcity or economic pressure	Trust is inhibited by the need for national survival. Love competes with duty to the starving.

In the strongest romantasy, your characters are changed by both the romance and the political conflict working together. The love interest provides the emotional safety or vulnerability needed for the protagonist to face their internal wound, while the political conflict provides the impossible challenge that forces them to find their strength. These two catalysts work in tandem. If your character only grows through love, the political plot feels decorative. If they only grow through political conflict, the romance feels bolted on.

How do love and politics each catalyse your protagonist's growth?

Your protagonist should grow through both the romance and the political conflict — not just one. If you can't fill in both rows, one of your plotlines may be decorative.

CATALYST	WHAT IT FORCES YOUR PROTAGONIST TO FACE	HOW THEY CHANGE
<i>The romance (emotional safety/vulnerability)</i>	<i>Feyre's bond with Rhys gives her the emotional safety to confront her trauma</i>	<i>She stops surviving and starts choosing to fight</i>
The romance (emotional safety/vulnerability)		
The political conflict (impossible challenge)		

Political Situations That Create Romance

PATTERN	HOW IT WORKS	WHAT IT CREATES
The forbidden union	Law prohibits their marriage	Secrecy, risk, "us against the world"
The arranged marriage	Political necessity forces them together	Forced proximity, duty vs. desire
The enemies	Their peoples/factions are in conflict	Loyalty tested, betrayal required
The political prize	One is valuable for political marriage	Competition, commodification, rescue
The hostage/ward	One is held by the other's people	Power imbalance, Stockholm dynamics
The succession crisis	Their relationship affects who rules	High stakes, public scrutiny

PATTERN	HOW IT WORKS	WHAT IT CREATES
The peace treaty	Their union could end a war	Pressure to perform, symbol vs. person

Political Character Pairings

PAIRING	BUILT-IN TENSION	KEY QUESTION
Royal + Commoner	Class law, succession, scandal	Can love override duty to bloodline?
Enemy nations	War, loyalty, treason	Can they choose each other over their people?
Conqueror + Conquered	Power imbalance, historical wrong	Can there be love without freedom?
Political rivals	Competing goals, zero-sum game	What would they sacrifice to win, or to love?
Arranged spouses	Obligation without choice	When does duty become desire?
Guard + Protected	Professional boundary, power difference	Can duty and love coexist?

Which type of political pressure operates in your story?

Most stories use more than one. Identify which apply and note the specifics.

PRESSURE TYPE	DOES IT APPLY?	HOW SPECIFICALLY?
<i>Prohibition (law forbids the relationship)</i>	<i>Yes — species law criminalises Fae/mortal unions</i>	<i>Marriage is void under Elfhame law; mortal has no legal standing</i>

PRESSURE TYPE	DOES IT APPLY?	HOW SPECIFICALLY?
Prohibition (law forbids the relationship)		
Compulsion (political forces push them together)		
Stakes (what they risk by being together)		

Map your political stake to a romantic obstacle:

Take the biggest political pressure in your story and translate it to the personal level. What does this political reality feel like in an intimate moment between your characters?

YOUR MACRO POLITICAL STAKE	YOUR MICRO ROMANTIC OBSTACLE

A Note Before You Begin

Not every question in this section will apply to your story. Skip what doesn't serve you.

If politics is background in your book, keep it simple. Not every romantasy needs complex political intrigue. Develop just enough to make the world feel real.

And politics can stay vague! Some stories work better with political structures that are felt rather than detailed. That's completely fine.

Common Mistakes

Mistake #1: The Toothless Law

There's a law against their relationship, but nobody enforces it. They're "forbidden" but face no real consequences. Forbidden love only matters if the forbidding has teeth.

FIX

Show enforcement. Someone else has been punished. Getting caught would mean concrete, serious consequences. In *Serpent & Dove*, the law against witchcraft has real teeth because we see other witches burned. Lou doesn't just risk disapproval; she risks being set on fire by the man she's falling for. That's a law with consequences, and it's why the forbidden love in that story actually feels forbidden.

Mistake #2: The Easily Escaped Arrangement

One character is in an arranged marriage, but they can simply refuse, or the other betrothed is cartoonishly evil so breaking the arrangement is obviously right. Arranged marriage tension requires the arrangement to be genuinely binding. If the arranged partner is a moustache-twirling villain, there's no real dilemma. The reader knows our protagonist should leave, and the tension evaporates.

FIX

Make the arrangement matter. Breaking it means war, family ruin, or personal destruction. And make the arranged partner human, maybe even decent. The hardest choices aren't between good and evil. They're between two things that both have legitimate claims on your character's loyalty. Make the choice genuinely hard.

Mistake #3: The Vague or Vanishing Politics

There's political conflict, but it's unclear what anyone wants, what the stakes are, or why it matters. Or: serious political conflicts somehow stop mattering when the romance heats up. External pressure disappears when it's inconvenient. If readers don't understand the political situation, they can't feel the pressure on the relationship. And if that pressure lifts the moment the leads start falling for each other, the stakes feel fake. Readers need to believe the world would genuinely punish these characters if they're caught. **Quick check: Does your story fall into any of these traps?** | Mistake | Does It Apply? | How You'll Fix It | ---|-----|-----| | Toothless law (forbidden but no real consequences) ||| Easily escaped arrangement (obvious that they should leave) ||| Vague/vanishing politics (unclear stakes or pressure disappears) |||

FIX

Be specific about who wants what and why both sides can't have it. Ground the conflict in concrete goals and consequences. Then keep the pressure on. Politics should intensify during the romance, not pause. The war doesn't stop because they're falling in love. The betrothal doesn't dissolve because they've had a meaningful conversation. The law doesn't look the other way because the reader wants them to be happy. If anything, the deeper they fall, the more dangerous their situation becomes.

Forms of Government

Different political structures create different pressures, different power dynamics, and different possibilities for your characters. The form of government you choose isn't just a worldbuilding decision; it determines what kind of romantic obstacle your story can sustain. A monarchy creates succession drama and forbidden love across ranks. An empire puts your characters in different conquered regions with different loyalties. In a theocracy, your characters' love may be considered a sin because of the nature of the religion they're living under. Choose the government that creates the pressure your romance needs.

The government type you choose shapes what kind of romantic obstacle your story can sustain. In *The Cruel Prince*, Elfhame's monarchy transfers power through cunning and murder, not just bloodline, which means Jude's mortal status isn't just socially awkward; it's a political death sentence that makes her romance with the prince an act of defiance against the entire system. In *Bridgerton*, the ton is like a small oligarchy of social power, marriage is a currency and every ball is a marketplace and a single scandal sheet can ruin a woman's future. It doesn't require a throne for the system to be an iron cage. You can mix and match elements or take into consideration regional differences. Think about how this system creates obstacles for your romance.

Political divisions between countries can keep lovers separated or provide escape routes for them. If your characters needed to leave, where could they go?

What form of government exists in your world?

Common options: monarchy (absolute, constitutional, hereditary, elected), theocracy, magocracy, oligarchy, democracy, empire, feudal system, tribal confederation, council, or dual systems where magical and mundane authorities coexist.

YOUR ANSWER

If your world has multiple nations, do they have different systems?

Political differences between nations can keep lovers separated — or provide escape routes. If your characters needed to flee, where could they go? If they come from nations with opposing systems, that's a built-in source of conflict.

YOUR ANSWER

How does your government type create the romantic obstacle?

You chose this government for a reason. What specific pressure does it put on your characters' relationship that a different system wouldn't?

YOUR ANSWER

Current Rulers

Who currently holds power?

This is the person (or people) that will decide the fate of your character(s). Are they pro-love or anti-love? What does the ruling body want, fear and prioritise? This matters because it reveals what they fear losing. If it is inheritance, they'll be afraid of other heirs that might take over. Conquest means they fear being conquered in turn. Election means they fear losing support. If they possess magical abilities, then they'll fear someone with even greater magical ability. Divine right means they fear religious challengers. If they came to power through a coup, then they'll fear the same thing happening to them again. Marriage alliance means they fear the spouse's family. Military force? Magic? Religion? Economic control? Spies and information gathering? Fear? Legitimacy and tradition? All power structures have some type of weakness. Rival claimants? Popular unrest? External threats? Succession crisis? Prophecy? Are your characters on opposing sides of the ruling body? Could their union bring stability or disorder to the realm? Will their relationship be used as a political tool?

Name your current ruler(s)

Be specific — name or title:

YOUR ANSWER

ASPECT	DETAILS
Title/Position	

ASPECT	DETAILS
Name	
How they gained power	
How long they've ruled	

How did they gain power?

This matters because it reveals what they fear losing:

Inheritance (fears other heirs, revolution), conquest (fears being conquered), election (fears losing support), magical strength (fears stronger mage), divine right (fears religious challengers), coup (fears the same), marriage alliance (fears spouse's family).

YOUR ANSWER

How do they maintain power?

Military force? Magic? Religion? Economic control? Information and spies? Fear? Legitimacy and tradition?

YOUR ANSWER

What do they want?

The ruler's priorities determine what threatens them — and your characters become a threat the moment their relationship conflicts with those priorities. What does the ruler want badly enough to destroy a love story over?

YOUR ANSWER

What threatens their rule?

Every power structure has cracks. Rival claimants? Popular unrest? External enemies? Succession crisis? Prophecy?

YOUR ANSWER

How does this instability affect your romance?

Are your characters on opposite sides? Could their union stabilize or destabilize the realm? Would their relationship be used as a political weapon?

YOUR ANSWER

How Laws Work

Knowing how laws are created, changed, and enforced will tell you what obstacles are truly immovable and which might bend. This matters for your romance because it determines whether your characters have any path other than defiance. If laws can be changed by petition, there's hope. If they're magically bound into the foundations of the world, your characters are up against something that can't be argued with.

When you're writing scenes involving law, don't have characters explain the legal system to each other. Instead, show what the law does to people. A character who flinches when guards pass, who hides a ring, who lies about their name at a checkpoint – that tells the reader everything about how the law works without a word of exposition.

Ruler by decree? Legislative body? Religious authority? Tradition that nobody changes? Magical compulsion?

Divine law, ancient compacts, magically binding treaties, things that can't be altered. Those are your most powerful romantic obstacles because no amount of political manoeuvring can remove them. Your characters must either break them, find a loophole, or accept them.

Who makes laws?

This determines whether your characters have any hope of changing the system that keeps them apart.

Ruler by decree? Legislative body? Religious authority? Tradition that no one changes? Magical compulsion?

YOUR ANSWER

Can laws be changed? How?

METHOD	HOW IT WORKS	HOW DIFFICULT
Ruler's decree		
Legislative process		
Religious reinterpretation		
Revolution/conquest		
Legal challenge/appeal		

Are there laws considered unchangeable?

Divine law, ancient compacts, magically binding treaties — things that *cannot* be altered:

YOUR ANSWER

Which law most directly affects your characters' relationship?

This is the law your reader needs to feel. Name it specifically — the law that makes their love dangerous.

YOUR ANSWER

Political Hierarchy

Hierarchy is shown by how characters act, not what they say. Who does the waiting? Who speaks first? Who sits while everyone else stands? Who has the right to interrupt and who has to be quiet? The physical dance of power, where we place ourselves in a room, who looks at who, shows us hierarchy without needing to tell anyone. When your characters are at different levels of this hierarchy, each and every interaction contains the burden of that difference. The upper ranked character can make casual assumptions, and the lower ranked character will always have to think about how to get by. Romantic tension in hierarchical gaps happens when the normal rules don't apply, when the powerful person asks instead of orders, when the powerless person won't let the powerful person tell them what to do. Map it from highest to lowest power: Birth? Achievement? Magical ability? Wealth? Military service? Marriage? Concentrate on the position(s) that your characters currently hold, want to hold or are trying to avoid. Who would give your characters their permission or protect them?

What's the political hierarchy?

Map it from highest to lowest power. For each level, think about the physical behaviours that show rank — who waits, who speaks first, who can interrupt. These details will make hierarchy visible in your scenes without exposition.

YOUR ANSWER

How do people move up (or down) in political power?

Birth? Achievement? Magical ability? Wealth? Military service? Marriage?

YOUR ANSWER

What positions exist that matter for your story?

POSITION	POWER THEY HOLD	WHO CURRENTLY HOLDS IT
<i>High Lord (ACOTAR)</i>	<i>Absolute rule over their Court, command of Court's magic</i>	<i>Rhysand — Night Court</i>

Magic & Political Power

If you have magic in your world, then magic is going to interact with political power. Who holds magic determines who is ruling and who your characters are allowed to fall in love with. Magic can either support or challenge existing power structures. When one of your characters has magic, this impacts both their place in society politically, and their romantic prospects in ways that may go unnoticed until these two come into contact. Is it hereditary (bloodlines hold power)? Learned (those controlling education hold power)? Granted by deities (those controlling access hold power)? Random (those who find and control magic-users hold power)? Those in power create barriers for others to obtain magic. Could your characters be barred from accessing magic, or forced to use magic against their own will? What's forbidden? What's required? How is magic regulated? This imbalance of power is evident in each social encounter. Your mage may not even realise that they're creating fear and intimidation. The non-mage may never feel completely at ease. The existence of these disparities doesn't evaporate simply because your characters are in love. Mixing bloodlines? Teaching forbidden magic? Creating a dangerous bond? Fulfilling or defying prophecy?

Who controls access to magic?

Is it hereditary (bloodlines hold power)? Learned (those controlling education hold power)? Granted by deities (those controlling access hold power)? Random (those who find and control magic-users hold power)?

YOUR ANSWER

Do mages rule, serve rulers, or oppose rulers?

Mages rule (magocracy): How do non-mages fit in? What happens to weak mages?

Mages serve: Are they conscripted, employed, or enslaved? What happens to those who refuse?

Mages are controlled: What laws restrict magic? How are mages tracked or eliminated?

Which dynamic exists, and how does it affect your characters?

YOUR ANSWER

Who controls access to magical power?

ASPECT	DETAILS
How is magic acquired (birth, training, divine gift, artifacts)?	
Who controls training/access?	
Can magical power be taken away?	

What laws govern magic use?

What's forbidden? What's required? What's regulated?

YOUR ANSWER

If one character has magic and the other doesn't, how does this affect their political standing?

IF ONE CHARACTER HAS MAGIC AND THE OTHER DOESN'T, HOW DOES THIS AFFECT THEIR POLITICAL STANDING?

Could your characters' relationship threaten the magical power structure?

Mixing bloodlines? Teaching forbidden magic? Creating a dangerous bond? Fulfilling or defying prophecy?

YOUR ANSWER

Law Enforcement & Justice

Enforcement gives force to laws. If the criminal aspect of your story has no real penalty, then there are no stakes. While the question “what’s against the law?” is important, the greater question is “what happens if they’re caught?” These are the individuals your characters will have to avoid, pay off, or confront. Royal guard? City watch? Magical enforcers? Religious authorities? Secret police? Self-enforcing magical contracts? Is enforcement ubiquitous (high risk)? Moderate? Weak or corrupt (easy to get away from)? Selective (depends who you are)? The degree to which the law is enforced provides much of the texture of your romance. In an omnipresent environment where everyone watches each other, the very act of stealing glances is a risk. Each whispered conversation could be overheard by someone who will report it. This creates a game of tradecraft: coded messages, secret meeting places, plausible deniability. When enforcement is weak, the danger occurs in fits and starts. Your characters may act with complete disregard for weeks and then one single misstep sends their world into chaos. If your characters are apprehended by the authorities, what will happen to them? Does class, wealth, species, or magical status affect how the law treats them? Be as detailed as possible regarding who receives special treatment. Make the consequences of your characters’ actions very tangible and escalating. How does punishment escalate with a first offence compared to subsequent offences?

Who enforces the law?

Royal guard? City watch? Magical enforcers? Religious authorities? Secret police? Self-enforcing magical contracts?

YOUR ANSWER

ENFORCEMENT BODY	WHAT THEY HANDLE	WHO CONTROLS THEM
<i>Chasseurs (Serpent & Dove)</i>	<i>Hunting and burning witches</i>	<i>The Church / Archbishop</i>

How effective is enforcement?

Omnipresent (high risk)? Moderate? Weak or corrupt (easy to evade)? Selective (depends who you are)?

YOUR ANSWER

What happens when your characters are caught?

SITUATION	CONSEQUENCE
<i>Example: First offense (Serpent & Dove)</i>	<i>Suspicion, investigation by the Church, social scrutiny</i>
First offense	
Caught together	
Marry illegally	
Produce children	

How does the justice system work?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Who judges (monarch, courts, religious authority, trial by combat)	
Are there trials?	
Do the accused have rights?	
Can verdicts be appealed?	
Who can afford good representation?	

Is justice equal?

Does class, wealth, species, or magical status affect how law applies? Be specific about who gets treated differently:

YOUR ANSWER

Unequal Justice

It is possible for one individual to receive a slap on the wrist for a violation of a law, while the other receives a death sentence for the same offence. Asymmetrical risk causes damage to relationships in many subtle and unspoken ways. When someone says “let’s take this risk together” they aren’t truly sharing the risk. The person who is protected by the law doesn’t realise the level of risk the unprotected person faces. The vulnerable partner is always thinking, always aware of what happens if they’re caught. For the protected partner who understands the risks that the vulnerable partner faces, there’s guilt. They enjoy the benefits of a system that would destroy the person they care about. The most open and honest relationships recognise and acknowledge the presence of this asymmetry. In *The Cruel Prince*, Jude is a mortal in Elfhame and has no protection under the law, whereas Cardan as a prince is beyond reproach. The dynamic between Jude and Cardan is defined solely by the fact that she is at constant risk while he isn’t. Jude is always thinking and calculating the potential consequences of each action she takes, because she knows that one incorrect step could result in her own death. Cardan can act without fear of consequence. In *Serpent & Dove*, the difference is even greater: if they’re discovered, Lou will burn alive while Reid will face shame and banishment. They’re not sharing the same level of risk, and the book does a good job of showing how this creates distance and tension in the space between them. Can the noble take responsibility and face the consequences? Or does the commoner bear the brunt? Can the magical character avoid punishment when the non-magical suffers? Is the protected character aware of the risk faced by the other? Do they attempt to protect them? Does the vulnerable character resent the inequality? Are they willing to give up their status? Would they admit

to having taken part so that both could be punished equally? What would it cost them? Would the protected character allow the other to face the consequences alone? Would they come forward? Would they even have the ability to save them?

Are laws enforced equally, or does power matter?

Does the noble face consequences, or only the commoner? Can the magical character escape while the non-magical suffers?

YOUR ANSWER

If one character risks everything while the other risks little, how do they navigate that?

Does the protected character understand what the other faces? Do they try to shield them? Does the vulnerable character resent the inequality?

YOUR ANSWER

Could the protected character sacrifice their protection for the other?

Renounce their status? Confess to share punishment? What would that cost?

YOUR ANSWER

What would happen if only one of them were caught?

Would the protected character let the other suffer alone? Would they come forward? Would they have the power to save them?

YOUR ANSWER

Diplomatic Protection & Special Status

Some positions grant immunity from normal laws, or make someone untouchable in ways that affect the relationship.

Does either character have special legal status?

Diplomatic immunity? Religious sanctuary? Royal protection? Magical immunity? Status as hostage or ward?

YOUR ANSWER

How does this status affect what they can do, or what can be done to them?

Special status can be both shield and cage. What freedoms does it grant, and what constraints does it impose?

YOUR ANSWER

Could their status protect the other character?

Could marriage, alliance, or association extend protection to their partner?

YOUR ANSWER

Could their status endanger the other character?

Does being connected to them make their partner a target? Create political complications?

YOUR ANSWER

What would they lose if they gave up their special status?

Could they renounce it? At what cost?

YOUR ANSWER



Trials & Justice

If caught, do your characters get a trial?

A trial creates narrative opportunity for public confrontation, defence, and dramatic revelations.

YOUR ANSWER

Who judges them?

Monarch? Court? Religious authority? Magical council? Trial by combat?

YOUR ANSWER

Can they appeal? Is there any legal recourse?

Hope of appeal can drive plot; no recourse raises the stakes considerably.

YOUR ANSWER

Who would or could defend them?

Allies willing to speak for them reveal the depth of support or isolation your characters face.

YOUR ANSWER

Power Gaps & Intimacy

When one character has the ability to imprison, exile, or kill another, how do you show that the less powerful character has given their consent? This is probably the most crucial craft question in romantasy, and if you get it wrong, you're going to turn a beautiful romance into one that leaves your readers feeling very uneasy. A gap in political power doesn't disappear just because characters are in love. The High Lord is still the High Lord. The mortal is still mortal. The Maiden is still forbidden from being touched. The issue isn't whether there is a power gap, but how your characters manage it, and how you, as the writer, demonstrate to the reader that the less powerful character is making their own decisions about entering into this relationship. Romantasy authors have used many craft techniques to show this to the reader, and they're worth knowing. **The rhetoric of choice.** In *ACOTAR*, Maas uses the way Tamlin and Rhysand handle power to make nearly all of the distinction between these two men. Tamlin removes Feyre's choices by confining her to his manor for her "safety," taking away her ability to choose while claiming he's protecting her. Rhysand on the other hand continually gives Feyre choices: to train, to fight, to govern, to leave. Maas is purposeful in her repetition. She's showing the reader that although Rhysand has enormous magical and political power, Feyre is being given the respect of having control over her own autonomy. Whether you find this fully convincing or not, the technique is certainly worth analysing. If your character who holds all the power is constantly giving the other character real choices, versus issuing commands disguised as suggestions, then the reader will have more faith in the dynamic.

The equaliser arc. In order to make the less powerful character credible in their own right, you need to ensure that when they consent to intimacy, it appears to be a conscious decision as opposed to a survival mechanism. In *From Blood and Ash*, Poppy is the Maiden, she can't be touched, spoken to, or seen. Her complete social isolation makes any intimacy a radical act of defiance. However, Armentrout gives Poppy an empathic gift and shows her to be a skilled warrior, ensuring she's not a damsel who has no other choice but to pick the one person protecting her. She's someone who can fight her way out, but has decided to remain. In *The Cruel Prince*, Jude doesn't possess any magical abilities at all, but her ability to lie (which the Fae can't do) becomes her most valuable weapon. Her "otherness", which initially presents itself as a weakness, becomes leverage. **The internal monologue as agency.** While a character may have many choices taken away from them due to political power, their internal voice becomes the reader's proof of consent. Rather than being swept up by feelings of attraction for Cardan, we see Jude acknowledge those feelings and manage them. We see Poppy weighing her conflicting desires before deciding what to do about them. The internal monologue tells the reader: this character is actively choosing, not being chosen for.

How does the power gap between your characters affect intimacy?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Who holds more political power?	
Does the more powerful character recognise the gap?	
How does the less powerful character exercise agency?	

ASPECT	DETAILS
What would it look like if the less powerful character said no? Would there be consequences?	

That last question is the most important one. If the less powerful character can't say no without facing punishment, exile, or death, you don't have a romance. You have coercion with good lighting. The reader has to believe that "no" is a real option, even if the character chooses "yes."

How will you show the reader that the less powerful character is choosing freely?

This is the most important craft question in any romance with a power gap. If you can't answer it, your readers will feel uneasy about the relationship.

CRAFT TECHNIQUE	HOW YOU'LL USE IT	EXAMPLE
Rhetoric of choice (powerful character gives real choices)		<i>Rhysand offers Feyre choices: to train, to fight, to govern, to leave</i>
Equaliser arc (less powerful character has their own source of power)		<i>Jude's ability to lie becomes her weapon in a world of Fae who can't</i>
Internal monologue as agency (reader sees the character actively deciding)		<i>Poppy weighs her desires before acting on them</i>

Sharing information instead of withholding it? Offering genuine choices? Respecting refusals without sulking or punishing? Training the other to be dangerous? All of these actions tell the reader the power gap is being navigated honestly.

Information, cunning, a unique ability, political leverage, the capacity to leave? The power doesn't have to be equal, but it has to be real. A character who has no power at all and no option to leave isn't in a position to consent, and your reader will feel that even if the character doesn't say it.

Marriage Laws

Romantasy typically utilises marriage law as the primary legal barrier. Once you know what is permissible, what is prohibited, and the penalties for crossing the line you'll have a very clear idea of what's standing in the way of your characters' love. There are generally several reasons marriage laws exist: to maintain power structures, to dictate who inherits property or titles, to keep classes or species separate, or to carry out the tenets of religious belief. Knowing the purpose behind the law will help you understand how rigid it is and how much effort would be required to challenge it. When you write marriage law into a scene, the best way to demonstrate its impact is through showing what it costs. A character watching two lovers being forced apart by guards at the altar. A guest list that requires approval from the Crown. A wedding ceremony that includes a loyalty oath to the state. By including these types of details, the law will feel realistic without requiring a lecture on the legal code. Consider the various types of restrictions imposed upon your characters: class, species, magical status, gender, family, religion, age, political status. Where your characters are of different species, these restrictions will have the greatest impact. Not just social disapproval, but serious questions regarding whether the union is legally recognised, whether children could exist, and whether they'd be viewed as people or abominations under the law. Provide a reason, regardless of how poor the reasoning may seem. Magical danger? Political control? Religious doctrine? Maintaining class system? Historical catastrophe blamed on forbidden unions? Religious ceremony? Legal contract? Magical binding? Consummation? Public declaration? Parental consent? Royal approval? Can divorce occur? Can annulment occur? Are magical bonds breakable? Or is marriage permanent? Are the consequences criminal (execution, imprisonment, exile)? Social (loss of title, disownment)? Magical (loss of power, curse)? Political (loss of succession rights, treaty violation)?

Who can legally marry whom?

Consider restrictions based on class, species, magical status, gender, family, religion, age, political status:

YOUR ANSWER

Why do these restrictions exist?

Give a reason — even if it's a bad one. Magical danger? Political control? Religious doctrine? Maintaining class system? Historical catastrophe blamed on forbidden unions?

YOUR ANSWER

What makes a marriage legal and binding?

Religious ceremony? Legal contract? Magical binding? Consummation? Public declaration? Parental consent? Royal approval?

YOUR ANSWER

Can marriages be dissolved?

Divorce allowed? Annulment possible? Magical bonds breakable? Or is marriage permanent?

YOUR ANSWER

What are the consequences of an illegal marriage?

Criminal (execution, imprisonment, exile)? Social (loss of title, disownment)? Magical (loss of power, curse)? Political (loss of succession rights, treaty violation)?

YOUR ANSWER

Class & Caste

Class divisions establish many of romantasy's most difficult barriers. The prince and the servant, the noble and the commoner. The reason class divides are such powerful obstacles is because of their structural nature, not the personal.

A large part of why class-based relationships are compelling is due to the differences in worldview. The noble has never been concerned with where their next meal will come from; the servant has never been able to afford the luxury of boredom. The experiential differences created by a class gap will result in misunderstandings, fascination, and conflict.

Class also defines an individual in a way that continues long after they become romantically involved with someone from a different class. When the servant marries the prince, that servant remains someone who was raised to serve. The best examples of class-based romantic obstacles involve individuals experiencing the differences between two worlds without pretending that those two worlds are comparable.

In *ACOTAR*, Feyre is brought to the Spring Court from such extreme poverty that she can't even read. She has no knowledge of the customs of the court, doesn't know which fork to use, and has no idea how to interact with a world where people can afford the luxury of boredom. This class barrier doesn't disappear once Feyre and Tamlin fall in love. Instead it influences each of their interactions, each misunderstanding, every moment that Tamlin takes for granted something Feyre has never known. In *Bridgerton*, the Sharma family must navigate a class system they weren't born into, a system in which knowledge of the rules is as important as the money one possesses, and one misstep in etiquette could destroy all that they've worked for.

What social hierarchy exists?

Map it from highest to lowest, including what determines class (birth, wealth, magic, achievement):

YOUR ANSWER

Where do your characters fall?

The larger the gap, the greater the romantic tension. What does each person assume as normal that the other has never experienced?

CHARACTER	CLASS POSITION	EXAMPLE (*SERPENT & DOVE*)
Protagonist		Witch (criminal class), beneath even peasants in the eyes of law, hunted and killed on sight
Love Interest		Chasseur Captain, military- religious elite, second only to the Archbishop, respected and feared

How many ranks separate them?

Same social class? One or two classes apart (scandalous but possible to bridge)? An extreme class gap (servant/royal)?

YOUR ANSWER

What laws enforce class separation?

Are there restricted areas or forbidden contact? What are the consequences if someone behaves above their station?

YOUR ANSWER

What social consequences exist for cross-class relationships?

Will they lose their status? Be disowned? Become socially isolated?

YOUR ANSWER



Species & Race Laws

What species exist in your world?

WHAT SPECIES EXIST IN YOUR WORLD?

What legal restrictions exist between species?

Intermarriage? Mixed-species children? Enslaved or second-class species? Segregated territories?

YOUR ANSWER

If your characters are different species, what laws affect them?

IF YOUR CHARACTERS ARE DIFFERENT SPECIES, WHAT LAWS AFFECT THEM?

Political Arrangements

Arranged marriages and political alliances have been romantasy tropes because they create forced proximity with high consequences. The characters didn't choose each other; however, now they must live with each other. The appeal of an arranged marriage lies within the conflict created when there's a difference between obligation and desire. They were brought together through duty, politics, or necessity. The question becomes: can anything real develop in soil that wasn't intentionally selected? It is this obligatory relationship versus a potential emotional one that creates both obstacles (if to someone else) and opportunities (if to each other) for romantic tension. Family (for alliance, wealth, bloodline)? Ruler (for political stability)? Religious authority (fulfilling prophecy)? Did the characters enter into an agreement on their own behalf? Legal repercussions? Magical oath? Political necessity? Pressure from family? No alternatives? Are they a potential ally (decent), a clear antagonist (cruel), in love with someone else as well (shared plight), or the one who will become the lover (arranged marriage to lovers)? War? Ruining of family? Losing safety? Magical backlash? Political instability?

Is one or both characters in an arranged marriage or betrothal?

If yes:

Who arranged it and why?

Family (for alliance, wealth, bloodline)? Ruler (for political stability)? Religious authority (fulfilling prophecy)? The characters themselves made a deal?

YOUR ANSWER

What makes the arrangement binding?

Legal penalties? Magical oath? Political necessity? Family pressure? No alternative?

YOUR ANSWER

Who is the arranged partner?

Are they decent (potential ally), cruel (clear villain), in love with someone else too (shared predicament), or the actual love interest (arranged marriage to lovers)?

YOUR ANSWER

What happens if the arrangement is broken?

War? Family ruin? Loss of protection? Magical backlash? Political chaos?

YOUR ANSWER

Already Bound

Often, the arranged marriage isn't something the characters have to get past. It's the basis for the story. They're already married. So now what? This configuration creates a different type of tension. The legal barrier is already removed. They're bound. The obstacle is internal: having to see each other as people and not just responsibilities, creating an atmosphere of trust that doesn't exist, developing genuine feelings in a relationship that originally existed as a transaction. In *Kingdom of the Wicked*, Emilia and Wrath enter into a magical marriage contract prior to either of them wanting this arrangement. Since there are no legal barriers, the emotional obstacles are much larger: she has no reason to trust a demon prince, he can't expose himself without putting her in harm's way as well, and their "alliance" is formed on top of conflicting agendas. The question is not if they can be together. It's whether being together will have any actual meaning if they were brought together as a strategic move. Right after the wedding? Months? Years of maintaining an icy wall of reserve? Were they friends or acquaintances prior to getting married? Was either one opposed to the union? Was there hope, dread, or resignation? Total strangers? Polite distance? Open hostility? Tentative curiosity? Do they need to appear as a couple? Produce an heir? Attend social events together? Share chambers? Separate bedrooms? Only limited conversations? Restrictions regarding what they can and can't share? What triggers the realisation for them to begin seeing each other in a different light? The legal barrier may be gone; however, what remaining emotional, political, or personal barrier will stay? Distrust issues? One is in love with someone else? They're on opposing sides of a conflict? One possesses a deep dark secret? When do they stop staying together out of obligation and begin to remain together out of desire?

If your characters begin the story already bound by political marriage:

How long have they been married?

Just wed? Months? Years of cold distance?

YOUR ANSWER

What were the circumstances of the wedding?

Did they meet before? Was one or both unwilling? Was there hope, dread, or resignation?

YOUR ANSWER

What's their relationship like at the start of the story?

Strangers? Polite distance? Active hostility? Tentative curiosity?

YOUR ANSWER

What does their marriage require of them publicly?

Must they appear united? Produce an heir? Attend functions together? Share chambers?

YOUR ANSWER

What private boundaries have they established?

Separate bedrooms? Limited conversation? Rules about what they will and won't share?

YOUR ANSWER

What begins to shift those boundaries?

What event, conversation, or realization starts changing how they see each other?

YOUR ANSWER

What's the obstacle now — if they're already married?

The legal barrier is gone, but what emotional, political, or personal barrier remains? Trust issues? One is in love with someone else? They're on opposite sides of a conflict? One holds a secret?

YOUR ANSWER

When does obligation become choice?

At what point do they stay together because they want to, not because they must?

YOUR ANSWER

Political Marriages & Treaties

When couples marry to serve the purposes of politics, both individuals become symbols as well as people. They're performing for their nations, not just for themselves. As a result of being treated as a political pawn, there's something about this experience that changes an individual's self-worth. You learn that your value is determined by what you can achieve, not by who you are. Couples that are married politically share something with each other that no one else sees, or they begrudge seeing the similarity in each other, it represents the loss of freedom and true choice. Whether true and lasting emotion can emerge from coercion is a question that has haunted many political marriages. If there were a choice, would these political pawns have selected each other? More often than not, the answer remains unknown and the couple must deal with this uncertainty. Political unions carry a weight far beyond how the individuals involved personally feel about each other. Their union could end wars or start them. Ends a war? Unites rival houses? Fulfills prophecy? Secures resources? There will be those that benefit from the relationship who will try to push the couple into forming a bond. There will also be those who feel threatened by their union, and will work to break them apart. Ultimately, the choices made regarding the consequences of refusing will dictate whether the couple is truly making a decision based on their own desires, or simply experiencing an illusion of choice. Are they resentful of having been compelled into this? Does a sense of duty reduce the genuineness of their intimacy? Can they develop a romantic relationship despite the arrangement, or do they struggle to believe in what they feel due to the coercion?

Is your characters' relationship politically important?

If yes:

What political problem does their union solve?

Ends a war? Unites rival houses? Fulfills prophecy? Secures resources?

YOUR ANSWER

Who benefits from their union? Who's threatened by it?

GROUP	BENEFIT OR THREAT
Who wants them together	
Why	
Who wants them apart	
Why	

What happens if they refuse the political obligation?

WHAT HAPPENS IF THEY REFUSE THE POLITICAL OBLIGATION?

How does political pressure affect their emotional relationship?

Do they resent being forced together? Does duty make intimacy feel less genuine? Do they fall in love despite the arrangement — or struggle to trust what they feel because of it?

YOUR ANSWER

Performing the Relationship

Sometimes the political situation demands that your characters pretend. Pretend to be in love when they're not. Pretend to be strangers when they're not. Pretend to be enemies when they're falling apart inside. The distance between the public performance and the private truth is one of the most reliable generators of romantic tension in the genre, because every public interaction is charged with what they can't say and every private moment is haunted by what they have to pretend.

There's a psychological reason this works so well. When people repeatedly perform the behaviours of love in public, declaring their partner's virtues to a court, touching them protectively, gazing at them with apparent affection, their internal feelings start to shift to match. You can't pretend to be in love eight hours a day and remain entirely unaffected. Eventually the performance starts to feel real because the body doesn't know it's acting.

In *The Bridge Kingdom*, Lara marries King Aren as a professional assassin sent to destroy his kingdom from the inside out. Lara's "performance" as a devoted wife is constantly undercut by the reality that she creates with Aren as they move through the dangers of the world together. She was sent to destroy him; she ends up loving him instead. The tension builds because Lara's internal dialogue documents exactly when the mission cracks, and when she starts to see that the man she was supposed to kill is honourable, faithful, and nothing like her father said he would be.

In *Radiance*, Brishen and Ildiko were both used as pawns in a marriage of convenience to facilitate a trade agreement between two species that found each other disgusting to look at. The public face they put on as symbols of peace was in direct contrast to their private lives as outsiders in their respective families. The reason the romance works is because they develop a legitimate friendship first, utilising humour and honesty regarding their physical appearance to form an intellectual connection. Once they develop a friendship based on respect, the feelings of affection grow, and eventually so do the feelings of desire.

Are your characters performing a relationship for political purposes?

If yes:

What are the ground rules?

All fake relationships begin with parameters: how much physical interaction can take place, what story they're going to tell the public, and when the pretence will stop. Establishing these boundaries is important because it's the violations of them that create the tension. The first time one character touches the other outside the established limits, or when one character defends the other more intensely than required by the scene, or when one character can't stop thinking about the performance when they're by themselves, the facade of their pretend begins to crumble. Affection? Unity? Hostility? Indifference? Which behaviours will the political situation require? Are the characters complete strangers? Enemies? Already attracted to one another, but pretending not to be? Is one character secretly working against the other? The instant the veil falls is your romantic turning point. At which point during the public display will the characters cross the line from acting strategically to feeling genuinely? A protective instinct that occurs too quickly to be calculated? A compliment intended for the court that the other character recognises as being true? A touch that lingers longer than the audience expects? Once the political goals of the situation are met or abandoned, and there's no longer a need for the characters to maintain the performance, will they continue to choose each other? The movement from "we have to" to "we want to" is the emotional core of this dynamic. Many of the most memorable romantic moments arise from the moment one character realises they're continuing to reach for the other's hand even though no one is watching.

What are the rules of the performance?

All fake relationships start with boundaries. The romantic tension comes from violating them.

RULE	DETAILS	EXAMPLE (*THE BRIDGE KINGDOM*)
What relationship are they performing? (love, unity, hostility, indifference)		<i>Devoted wife — Lara performs loyalty while secretly planning assassination</i>
Physical boundaries (what contact is and isn't allowed)		
When does the performance end?		
Is one secretly working against the other?		

What's the first boundary violation?

The moment one character crosses the performance's limits — a touch that lingers, a defence that's too fierce, a compliment that's true — is your romantic turning point.

YOUR ANSWER

When does the performance become real?

At what point does one character realise they're reaching for the other's hand even though no one is watching?

YOUR ANSWER

Factions & Opposition

Your couple doesn't exist in a vacuum. Political factions may support or oppose them based on how the relationship affects larger power struggles. Factions turn a love story into a political event. The moment your characters' relationship becomes known, every faction recalculates. Some see opportunity: this union could tip the balance their way. Others see a threat that must be eliminated. Your characters stop being just two people in love. They become pieces on a board, and factions will try to play them whether they like it or not.

Focus on factions that would care about your characters' relationship, either to support or destroy it.

Court intrigue? Elections? Military power? Economic pressure? Magical conflict?

Factional loyalty creates another layer of obligation and potential betrayal in the romance.

Being on the same side creates shared purpose; being on opposite sides creates the richest enemies-to-lovers tension.

The moment of choosing love over loyalty is one of the most powerful beats in enemies-to-lovers. What would push them to it?

What major factions exist?

FACTION	WHAT THEY WANT	WHO LEADS THEM	THEIR POWER BASE
<i>Court of Nightmares (ACOTAR)</i>	<i>Power over the Night Court, return to old cruelties</i>	<i>Keir</i>	<i>Ancient nobility, military strength, fear</i>

Where do your characters fall?

CHARACTER	FACTION
Protagonist	
Love Interest	

Are they on the same side, opposite sides, or unaligned?

Same side creates shared purpose; opposite sides creates enemies-to-lovers tension; unaligned means one or both will eventually be forced to choose. Each configuration generates different romantic pressure.

YOUR ANSWER

If on opposite sides, what would it take to betray their faction for each other?

IF ON OPPOSITE SIDES, WHAT WOULD IT TAKE TO BETRAY THEIR FACTION FOR EACH OTHER?



Political Enemies

Who has political reason to keep your characters apart?

Name specific antagonists. What do they stand to lose if your characters unite?

ENEMY	POSITION	WHAT THEY WANT	WHY THEY OPPOSE	WHAT THEY'LL DO
<i>Amarantha (ACOTAR)</i>	<i>Self-appointed ruler Under the Mountain</i>	<i>Dominion over all Courts</i>	<i>Feyre and Rhysand's bond threatens her control</i>	<i>Torture, manipulation, death trials</i>



Political Allies

Who supports your characters despite political opposition?

Allies provide hope and aid, but their support should cost them something too.

ALLY	POSITION	WHY THEY HELP	WHAT THEY RISK

Is there current factional conflict that affects your story?

Political instability creates both danger and opportunity. Could your characters use factional conflict to their advantage?

YOUR ANSWER

Court Politics & Intrigue

Courts represent the world where romantasy thrives. Wherever you find your characters, whether it's a Fae high court, a demon prince's hall, or a Regency ballroom, the court is a stage where every single interaction is both personal and political. So why do courts make such great romantic settings? Because everyone at court is "on stage," performing their roles, and the romantic tension arises from the disconnect between what they claim to be publicly and who they truly are privately. In a court setting, all eyes are on your characters, creating a constant sense of surveillance. Any small act of private truth performed in a court setting can become revolutionary due to this constant observation. A lingering look becomes a political statement. A dance can be a form of negotiation. One whispered word to the wrong person can be enough to topple an alliance or spark a war. In *ACOTAR*, Feyre and Rhysand attend the Court of Nightmares, which requires them to portray themselves as the wicked, untouchable High Lord and Lady. Feyre must fight the urge to say "thank you" to the servants, and therefore appear cruel, while Rhysand objectifies her in front of his enemies. Their performance is strategic: it keeps their enemies from discovering the private truth of Velaris. However, the tension generated comes from the emotional cost to Feyre and Rhysand, and the intimacy of being the only two individuals in the room who understand the truth. In *Bridgerton*, the London Season is a social whirlwind of balls and assemblies where young people are placed on exhibit. The rules for ballroom etiquette are rigid: men must ask to dance, women can only refuse to dance if she rejects all other dances offered, and there can be no physical contact outside of the momentary possibility of touching hands. Every dance is a spectator event, with chaperones and gossip columnists watching for even the slightest sign of scandal. If yes, consider how the court environment affects your characters. What role must they portray? What happens when the mask falls?

Masks

The mask is the main obstacle to an emotional connection in a court setting and also the primary source of suspense. All court characters wear a mask, and the romantic tension is created by the moments when those masks crack. Both leads in *The Cruel Prince* use cruelty as a shield. Cardan uses his casual cruel behaviour and bullying to hide his deep-rooted fear of being vulnerable and the abuse he experienced within his family. Jude wears a mask of complete coldness and calculated strategy to cover her mortal fragility. The romantic spark ignites in the moments these masks slip: when Cardan stops someone from hurting Jude and then quickly puts back on his mask of cruelty, or when Jude uses a kiss to test her power over him, whether she intends it as punishment or desire. In *Kingdom of the Wicked*, the names of the Seven Demon-Princes are titles of sin and serve as masks

What mask does each character wear at court?

The romantic spark happens when masks crack. You need to know what each character is hiding before you can write the moments it slips.

CHARACTER	PUBLIC MASK	WHAT IT HIDES	EXAMPLE (*THE CRUEL PRINCE*)
Cardan	Casual cruelty and indifference	Abuse trauma, isolation, fear of vulnerability	
Protagonist			
Love Interest			

What court ritual creates romantic pressure for your characters?

Balls, coronations, tournaments — public rituals force your characters into proximity under observation. The best romantic moments happen when the performance cracks during the event.

YOUR ANSWER

Where is the private space where the masks come off?

The contrast between public performance and private truth drives the romantic arc. Where can your characters be themselves?

YOUR ANSWER

Do your characters navigate court as partners or adversaries?

Partners build intimacy through shared burdens. Adversaries build tension through strategic counterplay. Both can lead to romance, but through very different paths.

YOUR ANSWER

What private language have your characters developed at court?

Surviving court together creates shared codes. These small, secret communications are some of the most romantic moments you can write.

PRIVATE SIGNAL	WHAT IT MEANS	EXAMPLE (*ACOTAR*)
<i>A specific look</i>	<i>"We need to leave now"</i>	<i>Feyre and Rhysand's daemati bond lets them speak while performing for the Hewn City</i>

Secrets & Espionage

Secrets in romantasy aren't side stories; they're obstacles to intimacy. Each time your character holds back some information from their romantic partner, it's an additional wall between them, and each time

they reveal a secret it opens a doorway that can't be closed. The core tension is this: your characters require deception to survive politically and honesty to feel intimate. They can't have both. That's the engine. When a character is keeping their true identity from their love, the relationship is built upon a false foundation. The romantic partner loves the version of a person the other has presented to them, not the entire person. The individual keeping the secret is also the person least capable of experiencing true intimacy, because their authentic self is never fully present in the same space as their partner. In *Serpent & Dove*, Lou has kept her identity as a witch a secret from Reid, a Chasseur that's been trained to kill her people. Both Lou and Reid enter into a marriage based on strategy, but as genuine feelings begin to develop, Lou's secret starts to poison their relationship. Reid's love grows stronger than Lou's because she's always keeping something guarded. She can never be fully in the same room with him. Each intimate moment is tainted by the reality that he'd set fire to her at the stake if he were to discover what she really is. In *Fourth Wing*, Xaden only shares with Violet "what you need to know." Violet is forced to question Xaden to obtain additional information. He can't share everything with her because of her close proximity to the state, exemplified by her mother's position and her friend Dain's ability to read memories. Their relationship relies heavily on physical attraction to provide a release, since their intellectual and emotional communication is consistently interrupted by the political implications of their connection.

Is either of your characters hiding their identity?

If yes:

ASPECT	DETAILS
What are they hiding?	
Who are they hiding it from?	

ASPECT	DETAILS
Why can't they reveal it?	
What happens if they're discovered?	
How does the secret limit the intimacy they can share?	

How does the secret create a ceiling on intimacy?

A character hiding their identity can never be fully present with their partner. The secret sets a maximum depth the relationship can reach — and the reader should feel that ceiling. What moments of connection are cut short or made hollow because of what's being hidden?

YOUR ANSWER

Espionage as Proximity

What spying does for characters is put them in charged close proximity. Intelligence gathering involves being close, observing behaviour patterns, finding vulnerabilities. As soon as the intelligence-gathering

targets the same individual as the character's potential love interest, the lines of distinction become blurred rapidly between professional surveillance and obsessive personal focus. In *The Cruel Prince*, Jude accepts membership into Prince Dain's intelligence organisation, the Court of Shadows, as a strategic move to gain leverage in a world where her mortality has made her extremely vulnerable. As a spy, she's required to observe the royal family closely, and through that observation she comes to know Cardan's private vulnerabilities: the abuse he endured, the isolation beneath his cruelty. The dynamic between them is fuelled by this difference in knowledge. Jude now understands the private pain Cardan has experienced, and that understanding is beginning to become entwined with her growing, unwanted desire for him. In *ACOTAR*, Feyre goes back to the Spring Court in *A Court of Wings and Ruin* to deliberately act as a spy and create events that will disassemble Tamlin's power from within. The difference that makes this a romantic beat is the comparison to her prior relationship: Tamlin used "safety" as a reason to control her, while Rhysand trusts her enough to share intelligence at a very high level and allows her to maintain complete autonomy over her decisions. Together they develop a deeper connection through the burden of strategy they share. The espionage serves not just the war plot; it demonstrates the equal partnership they have. Formally (as an assigned spy) or informally (watching, learning, figuring out who they really are)? When a spy finds out something that humanises their subject, something that causes them to see beyond the political role to the person beneath, that's one of the most powerful romantic beats in the genre. What does your character find out?

Is either character spying on or gathering intelligence about the other?

Espionage creates charged proximity. When your character is watching someone closely for strategic reasons, that observation often blurs into personal fascination.

YOUR ANSWER

What does your character discover that humanises their target?

The moment a spy sees past the political role to the person beneath is one of the most powerful romantic beats in the genre.

YOUR ANSWER

The Revelation

The moment a secret is revealed is the most structurally important romantic beat in any story built on hidden identities. It's the point where the relationship either deepens or shatters, and it forces both characters to choose what they value more: the safety of the lie or the risk of the truth.

In *Serpent & Dove*, when Reid discovers Lou is a witch, his first response is to declare they're "not really married." Both of them have to address their preconceived notions due to this revelation. But the story doesn't stop there. Reid's own identity crisis, discovering that he possesses magic himself, dismantles his certainty and forces him to choose between the Church's doctrine and the woman he loves. The revelation isn't a single moment; it's a cascade that strips away everything both characters thought they knew.

In *Fourth Wing*, the revelation that the Venin exist and that Navarre has lied for centuries is a seismic shift. But what nearly destroys the relationship is the discovery that Xaden knew Violet's brother Brennan was alive for six years while she grieved him. The political secret is forgivable. The personal betrayal, layered on top of the political one, is what turns the relationship from a forbidden romance into an ideological conflict.

Craft note: the most effective revelations aren't clean. They don't happen in one conversation. They cascade. One secret leads to another. The first revelation forces a re-evaluation; the second forces a crisis; the third forces a choice. With each layer stripped away, your characters are left standing in front of each other with nothing left to hide.

Early (and the story is about navigating the aftermath)? At the midpoint (raising the stakes for the second half)? At the climax (forcing the final choice)?

Voluntary confession? Accidental discovery? Betrayal by a third party? Forced by circumstances?

Some revelations deepen the bond. Some shatter it. Some do both at once. The answer depends on what was hidden, why it was hidden, and whether the one who lied can offer something more than “sorry.”

Trust After Betrayal

After the big reveal, the heavy lifting begins. The cat’s out of the bag. Now what? A great many romantasy novels will put the two main characters through a time of separation after the reveal: the third-act breakup. Not only is this dramatic, it provides a lot of room for character growth for each of them. The party who kept the secret has to come to terms with the damage their actions caused. The party who was deceived has to figure out if knowing why someone betrayed them is enough, or if they require some other type of reconciliation. In *Fourth Wing*, Violet comes to realise she’s in the same boat with her friends that Xaden was in with her: lying to the people you love to protect them. That comparison doesn’t take away from the betrayal, but it gives Violet a new way to view it. Their relationship grows into maturity when she goes from “you lied to me” to “I see why, and I am still hurt.” Words are not nearly as important as actions at this point. What tangible, concrete item can they provide? Just because you understand why someone acted a certain way, it doesn’t mean you’re automatically forgiving them. You can understand someone’s motivations and still be hurt by what they did. However, most times, understanding is the first step. Usually the person who was deceived gains the upper hand morally, and the person who lied typically has their standing diminished. How does this shift affect the relationship going forward?

When is the secret revealed?

The revelation is your most structurally important romantic beat. When it falls in the story determines what kind of tension you’re building.

ASPECT	DETAILS
What secret is revealed?	
When in the story? (early / midpoint / climax)	

ASPECT	DETAILS
How? (confession / discovery / betrayal by third party / forced)	
Does it deepen or shatter the bond?	

If your secret unravels in layers, map the cascade:

The most effective revelations aren't one conversation — they're a chain reaction. Each layer stripped away raises the stakes.

LAYER	WHAT'S REVEALED	WHAT IT FORCES
<i>First revelation</i>	<i>Xaden knew about the Venin</i>	<i>Re-evaluation of everything he's said</i>
First revelation		
Second revelation (deeper)		
Third revelation (forces the choice)		

What does trust look like after the betrayal?

Words aren't enough. What concrete action does the character who lied take to rebuild trust?

YOUR ANSWER

Warfare & Military

War is the most extreme form of political pressure. It will separate lovers, create impossible loyalty choices for characters, and put them on opposing sides. War also has a way of changing an individual, and characters who have experienced combat will take that experience into their relationships. The nature of the conflict sets limits to what's possible for your characters and the risks they take in being with one another. When you know the conflict, you'll know the costs your characters incur in choosing one another. Fragile peace has its own forms of tension. Can the choice of your characters for each other tip the scales towards war or lasting peace? Rationing? Curfews? Suspicion of outsiders? Refugees? Economic hardship? Absent family members? Volunteers? Conscripts? Nobility obligated to fight? Mercenaries? Magical warriors? A professional standing army? For whom? At what age? For how long? Can it be avoided, and if so how? Do people view those who serve honourably? Do they fear them? Pity them? Look down on them? Does this view vary based on rank? Service in the military provides duty that may oppose love as well as experiences that change a person. Absence and separation? Emotional distance and PTSD? Skills that are attractive but potentially frightening? Duties that conflict with love?

The State of Conflict

Is your world at war, at peace, or somewhere in between?

The state of conflict determines the risks your characters face for being together and the pressures that keep them apart or force them into proximity.

- Active warfare (battles happening now)
- Cold war (hostility without open conflict)
- Fragile peace (war recently ended or about to begin)
- Long peace (generations without major conflict)
- Perpetual low-level conflict (border skirmishes, raids, never fully resolved)

YOUR ANSWER

If at war: who's fighting whom, and why?

IF AT WAR: WHO'S FIGHTING WHOM, AND WHY?

If at peace: what threatens to break it? What tensions simmer beneath the surface?

IF AT PEACE: WHAT THREATENS TO BREAK IT? WHAT TENSIONS SIMMER BENEATH THE SURFACE?

How does the state of conflict affect daily life?

Rationing? Curfews? Suspicion of outsiders? Refugees? Economic strain? Absent family members?

YOUR ANSWER

Military Service

Who serves in the military?

Military service creates duty that competes with love, and shapes who your characters are allowed to associate with.

Volunteers? Conscripts? Nobility obligated to fight? Mercenaries? Magical warriors? A professional standing army?

YOUR ANSWER

Is military service required?

Mandatory service can separate lovers, delay unions, or create the very proximity that sparks the romance.

For whom? At what age? For how long? Can it be avoided — and how?

YOUR ANSWER

What's the social status of soldiers?

Honored? Feared? Pitied? Looked down upon? Does it vary by rank?

YOUR ANSWER

Is either of your characters in military service?

If yes:

ASPECT	DETAILS
<i>Example (Fourth Wing)</i>	<i>Violet Sorsengail — cadet / rider — because her mother commands it — has survived the Gauntlet and bonded two dragons</i>
Which character	
Role/rank	
Why they serve	
What they've seen or done	

If one character is a soldier, how does this affect the relationship?

Absence and separation? PTSD and emotional distance? Skills that are attractive or frightening? Duty that conflicts with love?

YOUR ANSWER

Enemies Across Battle Lines

If your characters are on opposing sides of the war and they develop an emotional connection, it's considered treasonous. The fact that they chose one another signifies they've betrayed everything they believed in since birth. This creates the ultimate high-risk enemies-to-lovers scenario; both parties have been trained since birth to distrust the opposing side. Each party will have its own propaganda and stereotypical views of the enemy based on what they've been told. Traitor? Spy? Corrupted? Foolish? Understandable but forbidden? What would they have to believe, learn, or experience? Does their union have political implications for the war? War leaves marks that don't heal. Violence changes people. How does this experience affect their capacity for intimacy and trust? Loss creates grief that shapes how they see the enemy and complicates falling for one of "them." Atrocities, massacres, betrayals during the conflict: inherited guilt or direct responsibility creates one of the deepest obstacles to overcome in enemies-to-lovers. Can there be forgiveness? Understanding? Or is this wound too deep? Execution? Imprisonment? Exile? Branded? Hunted? What would push them to it? What would they lose? Welcomed? Suspected? Used for information then discarded? Tested? Victory for one side? Negotiated peace? Exhaustion? Outside intervention? Symbol of unity? Marriage alliance? Proof that peace is possible? What would each side have to give up or accept? Peace doesn't erase memory. Think about whether society would accept them even after the conflict ends.

Are your characters on opposite sides of a conflict?

If yes:

ASPECT	PROTAGONIST	LOVE INTEREST
<i>Example (The Bridge Kingdom)</i>	<i>Lara — Maridrina's war against Ithicana</i>	<i>Aren — defending Ithicana's bridge and sovereignty</i>
What conflict		
Their side		

What does each side believe about the other?

Propaganda, stereotypes, justified grievances:

SIDE	WHAT THEY BELIEVE ABOUT THE ENEMY
Protagonist's side	
Love interest's side	

What would each character's people say about them loving the enemy?

Traitor? Spy? Corrupted? Foolish? Understandable but forbidden?

YOUR ANSWER

What would it take for them to choose each other over their side?

What would they have to believe, learn, or experience?

YOUR ANSWER

Could their relationship end the conflict — or make it worse?

Does their union have political implications for the war?

YOUR ANSWER

The Violence They Carry

Has either character killed in war?

If yes:

ASPECT	DETAILS
Which character	
Circumstances	
How it affects them	

Has either character lost someone to the conflict?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Who was lost and how	
How it shapes them	

Is there blood between their peoples that can't be easily forgiven?

Atrocities, massacres, betrayals during the conflict:

YOUR ANSWER

Does one character bear responsibility (personally or ancestrally) for violence against the other's people?

DOES ONE CHARACTER BEAR RESPONSIBILITY (PERSONALLY OR ANCESTRALLY) FOR VIOLENCE AGAINST THE OTHER'S PEOPLE?

How do they navigate this?

Can there be forgiveness? Understanding? Or is this wound too deep?

YOUR ANSWER

Desertion & Defection

What happens to deserters in your world?

Execution? Imprisonment? Exile? Branded? Hunted?

YOUR ANSWER

Could either character desert or defect for the relationship?

What would push them to it? What would they lose?

YOUR ANSWER

If one defects to the other's side, how are they received?

Welcomed? Suspected? Used for information then discarded? Tested?

YOUR ANSWER

War's End

How might the conflict end?

Victory for one side? Negotiated peace? Exhaustion? Outside intervention?

YOUR ANSWER

Could your characters' relationship play a role in ending the conflict?

Symbol of unity? Marriage alliance? Proof that peace is possible?

YOUR ANSWER

What would peace cost?

What would each side have to give up or accept?

YOUR ANSWER

In peacetime, could they be together openly — or would old hatreds persist?

IN PEACETIME, COULD THEY BE TOGETHER OPENLY — OR WOULD OLD HATREDS PERSIST?

Enemies to Lovers

“Enemies to lovers” is a common trope in romantic fiction and unfortunately, one of the least developed. In far too many cases, the “enemies” dislike each other for reasons that vanish when attraction becomes apparent. To make enemies-to-lovers believable, you need to create a world where there are actual grounds for hatred between the two characters. Not misunderstanding. Real, structural reasons why these two people should hate each other. Misunderstandings create obstacles that will disappear once cleared up. True hostility creates obstacles that take hard work, sacrifice, growth or transformation to resolve. That’s what makes enemies-to-lovers satisfying: seeing two individuals work through real grievances and not discovering they never had any. Sometimes the hostility existed prior to the two characters meeting. They inherited it. Conquest? Massacre? Betrayal? Enslavement? Theft of land or magic? Be specific. An “ancient grudge” is not enough. Is it living memory? Grandparents’ generation? Or centuries ago but never forgotten? Are there scars on the land? Displaced peoples? Stolen artefacts? Suppressed culture? Ongoing inequality? Do the two feel personal guilt for the hostility, or is the hostility something they consider to be “the past”? The greatest enmity is when one has caused direct harm to the other. Personal harm creates the most intense enmity. Be specific as to what harm was done. The two individuals’ interpretation of the harm will determine if there’s any possibility for forgiveness. Guilt provides a pathway to reconciliation; justification means the individual must change their worldview before there’s any opportunity for forgiveness. Death? Confession? Reparation? There’s no path forward without addressing this. Can some things not be forgiven? If one killed the other person’s family, then “sorry” is not enough. Sometimes the two are enemies because they hold fundamentally opposing views regarding how the world works. When there is ideological conflict, the two characters must confront the fact that they’ve been taught genuinely opposing values, not merely misunderstanding. It’s not sufficient to say “they were raised that way.” What experiences, evidence, or reasoning does each character have to support their belief? If so, the story is about one character realising they were mistaken, which is perfectly acceptable, but different than true ideological conflict. If both beliefs have validity, the story is about synthesising the two, or coming to terms with the differences, which is much more complicated.

The Foundation: Why Are They Actually Enemies?

Which of these creates the conflict between your characters?

Check all that apply and note specifics:

☐

Opposing sides of a war or conflict

They or their peoples are literally trying to kill each other.

SPECIFICS

YOUR ANSWER

☐

Historical wrongs between their peoples

One group harmed the other in ways that haven't been forgiven.

SPECIFICS

YOUR ANSWER

☐

Directly opposed goals

What one wants requires destroying what the other wants.

SPECIFICS

YOUR ANSWER

☐

One has power over the other (and has used it)

Master/slave, conqueror/conquered, oppressor/oppressed.

SPECIFICS

YOUR ANSWER

☐

One has personally harmed the other (or their loved ones)

Not their peoples — them specifically. Direct personal injury.

SPECIFICS

YOUR ANSWER

☐

Fundamentally opposed beliefs or values

What one considers moral, the other considers evil.

SPECIFICS

YOUR ANSWER

☐

Competition for something only one can have

Throne, position, resource, territory — winner takes all.

SPECIFICS

YOUR ANSWER

☐

One represents the system that oppresses the other

Even if they didn't create it, they benefit from and enforce it.

SPECIFICS

YOUR ANSWER

How many of these apply to your story?

1: You have a foundation. Consider whether it's strong enough.

2-3: Good complexity. Multiple layers of conflict.

4+: Rich enmity, but make sure it's not insurmountable.

The Legitimacy Test

Could a reasonable person, knowing what your protagonist knows, hate your love interest?

Not just dislike — *hate*. If the answer is no, your enmity isn't strong enough.

YOUR ANSWER

Could a reasonable person, knowing what your love interest knows, hate your protagonist?

Enemies to lovers works best when both have legitimate grievances.

YOUR ANSWER

Types of Political Enmity

Historical Enemies

What historical wrong exists between their peoples?

Conquest? Massacre? Betrayal? Enslavement? Theft of land or magic?

YOUR ANSWER

Who did what to whom?

Be specific. Vague “ancient grudge” isn’t enough.

YOUR ANSWER

How recent is this history?

Living memory? Grandparents' time? Centuries ago but never forgotten?

YOUR ANSWER

What evidence of this history remains?

Scars on the land, displaced peoples, stolen artifacts, suppressed culture, ongoing inequality?

YOUR ANSWER

How does each character relate to this history?

Do they feel personal guilt/grievance, or do they see it as “the past”?

CHARACTER	RELATIONSHIP TO HISTORICAL WRONG
Protagonist	
Love Interest	



Personal Enemies

What did one character do to the other (or their loved ones)?

WHAT DID ONE CHARACTER DO TO THE OTHER (OR THEIR LOVED ONES)?

Was it intentional, justified (in their mind), or accidental?

WAS IT INTENTIONAL, JUSTIFIED (IN THEIR MIND), OR ACCIDENTAL?

Does the one who caused harm feel guilty, justified, or conflicted?

DOES THE ONE WHO CAUSED HARM FEEL GUILTY, JUSTIFIED, OR CONFLICTED?

What would justice look like to the wronged party?

Death? Confession? Reparation? There's no path forward without addressing this.

YOUR ANSWER

Can this harm actually be forgiven?

Some things can't be — and pretending otherwise insults readers. If one killed the other's family, "sorry" doesn't cut it.

YOUR ANSWER



Ideological Enemies

What does each character believe that the other finds repugnant?

CHARACTER	BELIEF THE OTHER FINDS REPUGNANT
Protagonist	
Love Interest	

Why does each believe this?

Not just “they were raised that way” — what experiences, evidence, or reasoning supports their view?

CHARACTER	REASONING BEHIND THEIR BELIEF
Protagonist	
Love Interest	

Is either belief clearly wrong?

If so, the story is about one character learning they were wrong — which is fine, but different from true ideological conflict.

If both views have merit, the story is about synthesis or accepting difference — more complex.

YOUR ANSWER

The Path from Enemies to Lovers

The Crack in the Armor

What does the love interest do that surprises the protagonist?

An act of kindness, mercy, honor, or vulnerability they weren't expecting:

YOUR ANSWER

How does the protagonist explain this to themselves initially?

Rationalize it? Distrust it? Assume ulterior motive?

YOUR ANSWER

What does the protagonist do that surprises the love interest?

WHAT DOES THE PROTAGONIST DO THAT SURPRISES THE LOVE INTEREST?

How does the love interest initially explain this?

HOW DOES THE LOVE INTEREST INITIALLY EXPLAIN THIS?



Seeing Through Their Eyes

What does the protagonist learn about why the love interest is the way they are?

Not excuses — context. The experiences, pressures, or reasoning behind their position.

YOUR ANSWER

How does this knowledge change the protagonist's view?

They don't have to agree. But do they understand?

YOUR ANSWER

What does the love interest learn about the protagonist's perspective?

WHAT DOES THE LOVE INTEREST LEARN ABOUT THE PROTAGONIST'S PERSPECTIVE?

How does this change them?

HOW DOES THIS CHANGE THEM?



The Point of No Return

What does the protagonist do that their side would consider betrayal?

Not just “has feelings” — an action that crosses a line.

YOUR ANSWER

What does this cost them?

WHAT DOES THIS COST THEM?

What does the love interest do that their side would consider betrayal?

WHAT DOES THE LOVE INTEREST DO THAT THEIR SIDE WOULD CONSIDER BETRAYAL?

What does this cost them?

WHAT DOES THIS COST THEM?

The Political Cost of Reconciliation

At a certain point in the story, each of the characters will have to opt for the relationship rather than their “sides.” This is the real test, and the world-building question is: what does this choice cost them politically? Not simply because they “feel” something. An actual action that represents crossing a boundary. Sacrifices make decisions mean something. What do they lose that they can’t regain? Community, family, identity, safety, purpose? A mirror moment would be when they both made the same choice of loving each other over their loyalties. Each should pay a price equal to the price of the protagonist’s sacrifice. They should both lose something of great importance. The answer should be “yes, but barely.” Their costs should be high enough that choosing each other was worth something. A symbol of peace? Evidence that you can reconcile after all of that? A catalyst for change? Or simply two people that found each other in spite of everything? Time spent on things that could have been different, lives lost, and the damage done to relationships that can’t be repaired. A good enemies-to-lovers story recognises that some wounds will never heal and some harm will always be present. The issue isn’t if they can remove the past from existence; it’s if they can create something worth having together regardless of it.

Reckoning with the Enmity

The Mirror Sacrifice

In the strongest enemies-to-lovers, both characters pay a price of equal weight for choosing each other. Map what each one loses.

CHARACTER	WHAT THEY SACRIFICE	WHY THIS COSTS THEM SPECIFICALLY
Protagonist		
Love Interest		

Are these sacrifices roughly equal in weight?

If one character gives up everything and the other gives up nothing, the reader won't believe they're true equals.

YOUR ANSWER

The Conversation That Has to Happen

What specifically needs to be addressed?

The historical wrong, the personal injury, the ideological divide — name it:

YOUR ANSWER

Who brings it up?

The one who was wronged? The one who caused harm? Does it happen naturally or get forced?

YOUR ANSWER

What does each character need to say?

CHARACTER	WHAT THEY NEED TO SAY
Protagonist	
Love Interest	

What does each need to hear?

CHARACTER	WHAT THEY NEED TO HEAR
Protagonist	
Love Interest	

Is there an apology? Is it sufficient?

IS THERE AN APOLOGY? IS IT SUFFICIENT?

Is there forgiveness? Is it earned?

IS THERE FORGIVENESS? IS IT EARNED?



What Can't Be Fixed

What damage from their enmity is permanent?

Lives lost, time wasted, trust that can never be fully restored:

YOUR ANSWER

How do they live with what can't be fixed?

HOW DO THEY LIVE WITH WHAT CAN'T BE FIXED?

Is there anything one can do to make amends — even if it can't undo the harm?

IS THERE ANYTHING ONE CAN DO TO MAKE AMENDS — EVEN IF IT CAN'T UNDO
THE HARM?



The Stakes of Reconciliation

If they choose each other, what does the protagonist lose?

Community, family, identity, safety, purpose:

YOUR ANSWER

What does the love interest lose?

WHAT DOES THE LOVE INTEREST LOSE?

Are these losses worth it?

The answer should be “yes, but barely” — the cost should be real enough that choosing each other means something.

YOUR ANSWER

World Impact

Does their relationship affect the larger conflict?

Symbol of peace? Proof that reconciliation is possible? Catalyst for change? Or just two people who found each other despite everything?

YOUR ANSWER

How do others react to their relationship?

SIDE	REACTION
Protagonist's side	
Love interest's side	

Enemies-to-Lovers Pitfalls

Use this to pressure-test your enmity:

Check: Is your enmity based primarily on misunderstanding?

CHECK: IS YOUR ENMITY BASED PRIMARILY ON MISUNDERSTANDING?

Check: Does attraction make them forget their legitimate grievances?

CHECK: DOES ATTRACTION MAKE THEM FORGET THEIR LEGITIMATE GRIEVANCES?

Check: Do they ever actually address the reason they were enemies?

CHECK: DO THEY EVER ACTUALLY ADDRESS THE REASON THEY WERE ENEMIES?

Check: Does falling in love make either character unrecognizable?

CHECK: DOES FALLING IN LOVE MAKE EITHER CHARACTER UNRECOGNIZABLE?

Succession & Heirs

If your characters come from influential families, then succession will impact the romantic elements of your story. Who they marry, whether they produce heirs, and which bloodlines those children will carry all have significant political implications. The pressure of succession can affect how your characters view their relationship. Each kiss weighs heavily as an heirloom of a dynasty. Each disagreement has the potential for a diplomatic incident. And whether or not your characters decide to have children is no longer just a personal choice; it's being debated in council chambers by individuals that will never hold the child. That loss of humanity is something you should be writing about. When your character finally understands that their body has been turned into a political resource and no longer a private possession, that's a moment that should weigh heavily. Inheritance adds layers beyond the personal. The choices your characters make today may impact the next generation. Can they lose inheritance due to marrying the wrong person? Must they marry to inherit? Does their union combine two inheritances? Expectations surrounding producing an heir can create significant pressure and conflict in relationships where producing an heir would be either impossible or difficult. Biological complications can be particularly damaging when certain family lines are deemed politically important. High-stakes inheritance and family drama increase the pressure significantly on their relationship.

What does each character stand to inherit?

CHARACTER	INHERITANCE
Protagonist	
Love Interest	

How does their relationship affect inheritance?

Marrying wrong costs inheritance? They must marry to inherit? Their union combines inheritances?

YOUR ANSWER

Is either expected to produce an heir?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Timeline	

ASPECT	DETAILS
What happens if they don't	

If they're different species or one is sterile, how does this affect heir requirements?

IF THEY'RE DIFFERENT SPECIES OR ONE IS STERILE, HOW DOES THIS AFFECT HEIR REQUIREMENTS?

Could their relationship cause or solve a succession crisis?

COULD THEIR RELATIONSHIP CAUSE OR SOLVE A SUCCESSION CRISIS?

Revolution & Reform

Sometimes, the antagonists of a romantic fantasy are the very systems we live under. The laws are unfair. The government is oppressive. The only way to be together is to change the world. In a romantasy this is a powerful path to follow as it transforms a love story from an individual relationship to a political one. Not only do the lovers want to be able to be together, but they also want to create a world where others like them can live openly. Their love becomes the evidence that the system is wrong. However, revolution is never clean. To bring about change, sacrifices will need to be made that go beyond the risks two people would normally take for one another. Revolution requires people to put others at risk. Revolution requires people to make decisions where regardless of which decision they choose, someone will get hurt. A romantasy that does a good job of handling revolution will not allow the couple to emerge with clean hands. Are there exceptions that can be appealed to legally? Are there ways to change the laws politically? Is waiting for a new ruler acceptable? Are there loopholes? If there's a lawful route available, the lovers have to decide whether to go down the long road of the law, or whether to break the system wide open. Who would they need to support them? At what cost? Who would die? What would cause them to move from living within the system to fighting against it? There's a major difference between surviving (reactive) and fighting (proactive), and the point of transition from one to the other is worthy of careful writing. Survival is a defensive action. Choosing to fight is a decision that fundamentally changes who they are. Safety? Family? Status? Each other? The willingness to sacrifice each other is the darkest form of this question and the most compelling. Revolution is never clean. Were lives lost? Was stability destroyed? Did they become what they were fighting against? Victory that comes with grief is more honest than victory without cost. Political world-building in a romantasy has nothing to do with creating a real government. It's about creating barriers that are meaningful and which require growth, sacrifice, or systemic change to overcome. If your lovers can simply disregard the laws or wait for the obstacle to resolve itself, then the obstacles you created aren't strong enough. But if breaking the law results in war, if being discovered means death, now you have something to write about.

Are there legal means to change the laws keeping them apart?

Appealing for exception? Changing laws politically? Waiting for a new ruler? Finding loopholes?

YOUR ANSWER

If peaceful change is impossible, what would revolution look like?

IF PEACEFUL CHANGE IS IMPOSSIBLE, WHAT WOULD REVOLUTION LOOK LIKE?

Would your characters join or lead a revolution?

What would push them from surviving the system to fighting it?

YOUR ANSWER

What would they sacrifice to change the system?

Safety? Family? Status? Each other?

YOUR ANSWER

What's lost even if they win?

Revolution isn't clean. Lives lost? Stability destroyed? Becoming what they fought?

YOUR ANSWER

Integration Check

QUESTION	ANSWER
How does your government control, use, or fear magic?	
What magical law most affects your characters?	
Could magic let them bypass political obstacles? If yes, why don't they?	
Does government have magical enforcement (truth spells, tracking, binding oaths)?	

The Core Political Obstacle

In one sentence, what is the primary political obstacle keeping your characters apart?

IN ONE SENTENCE, WHAT IS THE PRIMARY POLITICAL OBSTACLE KEEPING YOUR CHARACTERS APART?

How can this obstacle be overcome?

- Changing who they are (gaining status, power, different identity)
- Changing the system (reform or revolution)
- Escaping the system (running away, exile)
- Accepting consequences (being together despite the cost)

Which path do your characters take?

YOUR ANSWER

When does the political obstacle force a choice?

The crisis point when they can no longer avoid confronting it:

YOUR ANSWER

Quick Reference: Political Stakes

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
The law(s) that forbid the romance	
Consequences if caught	
Who enforces and how aggressively	
Political enemy who opposes them	
Political ally who supports them	
State of conflict (war/peace)	

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
Military obligations affecting the romance	
Source of genuine enmity (if enemies-to-lovers)	
What each loses by choosing the other	
The political crisis point	
How it resolves	